WHITE FANG by Jack London
(A2–A2+)

INTRODUCTION

Ss read an extract from *White Fang* by Jack London in which White Fang is tamed by his new owner, Scott. Ss find out about the Gold Rush, wolves and the history of dogs as pets.

Supplementary Materials

WARM UP: pictures of different breeds of dog, e.g. dalmation, terrier, German Shepherd

ACTIVE INVESTIGATION: internet access

CLIL CONNECTION: internet access

Culture notes

Jack London

Jack London's real name was John Griffith Chaney. He was born in 1876 in San Francisco. Many of his books are about the struggles of men and animals against hardships and the realities of life and nature told in a vivid and exciting style. He became an extremely popular writer in the early years of the twentieth century and remains a great favourite today. He wrote more than 50 books between 1900 and 1915 and died, aged 40, in 1916.

White Fang

White Fang is a heart-warming story of how a wild animal, part wolf and part dog, comes to love and live happily with a human family. The story is set in Canada in the 1890s – around the time of the Gold Rush in the Klondike. The story shows White Fang through his life with different owners, some who treat him with cruelty and turn him into an angry and dangerous animal, until a man called Weedon Scott rescues him and shows him kindness. The book shows us how brutality, hate and anger, even in a wild animal, can be overcome by the civilising effect of the better side of human nature: compassion, gentleness and affection. It was made into a film starring Ethan Hawke in 1991.

The Gold Rush

In 1896, gold was found where the Klondike River joins the Yukon River and large numbers of people came up from the south, from San Francisco and other parts of California, hoping to make their fortunes.

WARM UP

Show Ss the pictures and see if they can guess the dog breeds. At the end of the activity ask *What do all dogs have in common?* (They came from wolves.) It doesn't matter if Ss don't get this answer but you may want to return to the question at the end of the lesson to remind Ss that all today's domestic dogs share a common ancestor with today's wolves.

PREPARATION

THINKING ROUTINE

1

see, think, wonder

Focus Ss on the picture of the wolf and the questions in *see*, *think* and *wonder*. Allow time for them to discuss the questions in pairs. Monitor and help with vocabulary as needed. Make a note of any useful words on the board. Check answers as a class.

ANSWERS:

see

1 A wolf; In the wild/a cold country/the woods or forest.

think

2 No, as it is a wild animal and likely to be dangerous. Ss may suggest it could be or has been trained and tamed or domesticated.

wonder

3 Ss' own answers

4 Ss' own answers. Possible answers: fearful, nervous, suspicious, hate people, not interested in them. They may predict the text, that humans seem like gods to the animal.

READING PREVIEW

Focus Ss on the title and ask *Can a wolf become a pet? What can you do to tame it?* Use this stage to pre-teach the word 'tame' (to train a wild animal to be a pet) if it has not come up in the earlier discussion.

READING EXTRACT LL3.01

Tell Ss they are going to read an extract from *White Fang* about how a man tamed a wolf. Allow time for them to read in silence, or play the recording while they read. If you're going to play the recording, focus on the glossary words in the box first so Ss will understand them when they listen and read.

When they have finished, ask *Were your ideas correct about how to tame a wild animal like Scott does with White Fang?*

While they are reading, write the following questions on the board:

- *Which character, the man or the wolf, do we feel more connected to when we read this story?* (The wolf)
- *Why?* (Because the writer puts us 'inside the wolf's head' and shows us his thoughts and feelings about the man and what's happening.)

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- *Why does White Fang call the man 'a god'?* (Because he has power, gives food, and is in control of White Fang's life and everything that happens.)
- *How do you think the man feels?* (Maybe nervous the wolf will attack him; perhaps hopeful that he and the wolf will be friends; determined that his plan will work.)
- *What can we guess about the wolf's life before this man found him?* (It was hard and people were unkind to him because we see he is afraid and angry at first and doesn't trust the man. We can also suppose he has run away from owners in the past.)

Encourage them to discuss the questions, in pairs, with reference to the text to support their ideas. Monitor and help with vocabulary as needed. In feedback, elicit Ss' ideas as a class.

COMPREHENSION

2 Focus on the questions and tell Ss their answers can be 1–3 words long and they do not need to write full sentences. Allow time for them to complete the questions individually and then compare with a partner.

Check answers as a class and encourage Ss to go back to the text to justify their answers, especially in the case of wrong answers so they can work out where they went wrong.

ANSWERS:

1 meat **2** on the snow **3** a god **4** Scott's hand
5 stroking/strokes **6** a) afraid b) he loved him

ACTIVE INVESTIGATION

3 Focus on the questions. Give time for Ss to answer or guess the answers from their own knowledge, then to compare ideas with a partner. Then allow time for Ss to research the answers online, in class or at home to confirm their ideas. In feedback, elicit Ss' answers as a class and ask if any of the things they found out were surprising.

ANSWERS:

1 Yes.
2 Between 600 and 1800 depending on the source.
3 National parks, e.g. The Abruzzo. Also Lazio e Molise, in Calabria, in the Pollino, on Appennino Tosco-Emiliano, and the Alps. Sightings in Tuscany, Bologna, Parma and Tarquinia and near Rome.
4 No, they're protected.
5 The government gives the farmer money.

SPEAKING

4A In their pairs, Ss talk about their feelings about wolves and if they have ever seen one. Monitor and help with vocabulary as needed. Share any interesting stories with the class.

B Focus Ss on the questions. Ss can discuss in pairs and predict some of the answers, then do additional research online if they need to. Monitor and help with vocabulary as needed. Check answers as a class.

ANSWERS:

1 Estimates vary but at least 12,000 years ago.
2 Answers will vary according to source but can also just be Ss' opinions based on their own observations.
3 Possible answers: guide dogs, rescue dogs, guard dogs, police dogs, security sniffer dogs, TV/film performing, medical companions that can smell when someone is going to have a stroke/fit, etc., astronauts (Laika).

CLIL CONNECTION

History

5 Tell Ss that the story is set in North America during the time of the Gold Rush. Ask *What is a Gold Rush?* If Ss aren't sure, ask them *What might happen if someone found gold in* (name a place in your town)?

Focus Ss on the questions and allow time for them to research online, in class or at home. Check answers as a class.

ANSWERS:

1 When gold is discovered (accidentally) and large numbers of people move there to find and mine it and get rich quick.
2 In Canada's Yukon territory in north-west Canada.
3 & 4 Ss do not need to find all of these: 1799, Carolina gold rush (US). 1829 Georgia gold rush (US). 1849 California gold rush (US). 1858, Fraser River gold rush (Canada). 1860–63, Cariboo gold rush (Canada).
5 They were often forced to leave, suffered diseases or were killed and mostly died out.

Homework ideas

- Ss write a story about seeing a wolf. It can be true or made up.
- Ss make an information poster informing people what to do if they see a wolf in the wild. They may need to research this first.
- Ss write a news article announcing gold has been found in their town.

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